

The world of fish

Fish have been around for 400 million years! They live in seas, rivers, and lakes. Wherever you find water, you can bet there are plenty of fish swimming around.

Types of fish

There are over 30,000 types of fish, which fall into three groups.



Bony fish: 95 per cent of the fish in the world are bony fish with hard skeletons.



Cartilaginous fish: rays, skates, and sharks make up this group.



Jawless fish: only hagfish and lampreys fall into this small group.

Pyjama cardinalfish

Bony fish have a skeleton with a skull, ribs, and a backbone.

Fish skin, made up of scales, is slimy to let them slip through water easily.

The gills lie behind the eyes.

Fish have fins that keep them upright when they swim.

The tail of a fish sweeps from side to side to push the fish forwards.

Gills

Like other animals, fish need to take in oxygen in order to live. But, unlike us, they can breathe underwater using their gills. Fish gulp in water and their gills filter the oxygen out of it.

Fish out of water

Mudskippers are one of the few kinds of fish that can survive out of water. They have special gills that take oxygen from air or water. They skip along mudflats using their fins as elbows.

Mudskipper

